

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

Game Title:

Risky Peaks



Intended Audience: Players aged 12 and above

The Game

Prototype:

GitHub portfolio:

<https://github.com/Coffey-coder/nightMonkeyGames.github.io>

<https://coffey-coder.github.io/nightMonkeyGames.github.io/> (Project Webpage)

Game Story

Risky Peaks follows Ogunda who is from a tribal village at the base of a dangerous and sacred mountain. When a mysterious sickness spreads throughout the village, the mountain becomes both the setting of danger and the symbol of hope. The theme centers around courage, responsibility, action and risk taking in order to save the village. Ogunda's job is to save the villagers by climbing the mountain to gather a mythical plant that is said to cure the sickness that affects the village. Along the way Ogunda must fight against the ancient mountain spirit while climbing through different levels.

Act 1:

Ogunda Climbah, a young climber from the village, is chosen by Chief Aruka to ascend the sacred mountain and retrieve a rare healing plant that grows only at the summit. Many villagers attempted the climb before him but never returned.

Ogunda begins his ascent guided by Elder Tohu, the spectral projection of a long-past village chief who was once a legendary climber. Elder Tohu teaches the basic climbing techniques, tools, and dangers, using his ancient knowledge of the mountain to prepare Ogunda for the trials ahead. Early in the journey, Ogunda discovers stranded climbers who failed in previous attempts. Using carved totems, he can rescue them or set checkpoints to aid his own survival. The inciting incident occurs when Ogunda witnesses the Mountain Guardian directly intervene, transforming the mountain around him and confirming that the guardian will not allow an unworthy climber to pass.

Act 2:

As Ogunda progresses through the middle levels, the mountain spirit changes tactics to break his resolve. Each section of the climb introduces a new obstacle tied to the spirit's growing hostility. In the "Sticky Slime" region, movement becomes slow and hazardous as the spirit covers the paths in binding slime, and stranded climbers must be carefully extracted before they are consumed. Later, in the "Cloudy Peaks", oxygen thins and visibility drops, forcing Ogunda to navigate shifting platforms and sudden obstacles hidden in fog.

Throughout these trials, Ogunda can choose easier or harder routes, and these decisions shape the difficulty of the summit. Temba continues to appear at checkpoints offering items and upgrades, though the spirit becomes increasingly enraged by the help he provides. This rising tension peaks when the mountain spirit destroys Temba's shop entirely, signalling that the final confrontation is close and that mercy toward stranded climbers will determine how the mountain judges him.

Act 3:

Ogunda reaches the summit where the Mountain Guardian confronts him in the final trial. The challenge adapts to the player's journey: if Ogunda rescued many stranded climbers, the mountain becomes gentler; if he neglected them, their spirits return as hostile forces alongside the guardian. This creates a final test not only of skill but of character.

During the confrontation, Ogunda discovers that the Mountain Guardians judgment is based on how humans treat one another during the climb. This recognition defines the ending:

If Ogunda saved all stranded - the Mountain Guardian sees compassion in him and opens a clear path to the cure plant. Ogunda returns home as a hero and is celebrated as the next village chief.

If Ogunda saved some stranded - Ogunda obtains the herb, but the Guardian remains wary. He is thrown back to the village unharmed, yet the villagers react with mixed feelings, unsure whether he acted out of duty or selfishness.

If Ogunda saved no-one - The mountain rejects him entirely. Hostile spirits overwhelm him, preventing access to the cure. He falls into despair, and the journey ends without saving the village.

Each ending concludes with a results screen showing XP, items gained, villagers rescued, and total time, reinforcing how the player's choices shaped the final outcome.

Characters

Protagonist:

Name: *Ogunda Climbah*

Age: young, 19 ish

Role: Chosen climber sent to retrieve the cure plant from the mountain peak.

Appearance: Ogunda wears fur-lined tribal climbing gear, a woven rope harness, and face markings symbolising protection. He carries a handmade climbing axe, a talisman from the village elder, and a small pouch for herbs.

Personality: Confident, observant, and empathetic. He is thoughtful under pressure. He relies on intuition and has a strong connection to nature.

Motivations: Save his village from the spreading illness. Honour the elders who chose him when all other climbers failed to return.

Goals: Reach the summit, retrieve the cure plant, navigate the mountain's hazards, and avoid the mystical bird guardian. He must prove he is capable and worthy of the tribe's trust.

Dramatic Need: To overcome self-doubt, trust his instincts, and accept fear as part of his journey.



Antagonist:

Name: *The Mountain Guardian*

Age: Ancient, ageless

Role: Mystical bird creature that guards the sacred (cure) plant at the mountain peak and transforms the mountain to test or repel climbers.

Appearance: A large, luminous bird with crystalline feathers that shift colour with the wind. Its wings create violent gusts capable of reshaping snow and stone. Its eyes glow with an intelligent, watchful presence. It appears both beautiful and intimidating.

Personality: Protective, territorial, and unwavering. The Mountain Guardian is not cruel but acts with strict purpose. It sees intruders as threats to the mountain's balance. It communicates through environmental changes rather than speech.

Motivations: Preserve the sacred plant and maintain the spiritual balance of the mountain. Prevent unworthy or unprepared climbers from disturbing what it protects.

Goals: Challenge anyone attempting to reach the summit. Test their resolve through illusions, shifting terrain, and harsh weather. Ensure that only a climber with true spirit and intention may approach the cure plant.

Dramatic Need: To uphold its ancient duty as a guardian. Its purpose is tied to the mountain itself, and it cannot allow the plant to be taken without proving the climber's worth.



Name: *Chief Aruka*

Age: Late 50s to early 60s

Role: Leader of the mountain village who chooses Ogunda for the sacred climb. Serves as the guiding figure and emotional anchor for the story.

Appearance: Chief Aruka wears layered robes woven from dyed animal fibres, decorated with carved wooden beads and feathers symbolising wisdom. His long grey hair is tied back with ceremonial bands. He carries a staff etched with tribal markings representing past chiefs.

Personality: Calm, wise, and deeply spiritual. Aruka is patient and compassionate but carries a heavy burden as the illness spreads through the village. He speaks softly but with authority and is respected by all.

Motivations: Protect the village and preserve its traditions. Ensure that the cure plant is retrieved by someone spiritually aligned with the mountain.

Goals: Guide Ogunda, offer blessings and knowledge, and prepare him mentally for the journey. Maintain hope in the village despite previous failed attempts.

Dramatic Need: To trust the new generation and accept that he cannot protect the village alone. He must let go of the fear of losing another climber.



Name: *Temba the Wanderer*

Age: Unknown (appears mid 40s but could be much older)

Role: A mysterious travelling merchant who appears at the end of each level to sell upgrades, tools, charms, and survival items in exchange for earned XP.

Appearance: Temba dresses in layered travelling robes stitched from many different cultures' fabrics. He carries a pack overflowing with trinkets, glowing stones, rope coils, dried herbs, and odd mechanical gadgets. His eyes have a faint shimmer that suggests he knows far more than he lets on.

Personality: Warm, talkative, and mischievous. Temba speaks in riddles and jokes but always gives the player exactly the hint they need. He seems to appear and disappear without leaving footprints, as if the mountain itself allows him to pass.

Motivations: To help worthy climbers survive the mountain's trials. He trades goods not for profit but to ensure that the right person reaches the summit.

Goals: Offer equipment upgrades, restorative items, charms that weaken the mountain's illusions, and tools that open optional paths. Encourage the player to keep pushing upward through the challenges.



Name: *Elder Tohu*

Role: A miniature spectral projection of Elder Tohu, an ancient former chief of the village who was once a legendary climber. He appears during the early levels to guide the player, teach controls, and offer hints. His knowledge of the mountain comes from his own past ascent many generations ago.

Appearance: Elder Tohu appears as a tiny, blue, glowing spirit figure with simplified, exaggerated expressions that make him easy to read during gameplay. His body is formed from soft swirling mist, and he floats effortlessly above the ground. His shortened spirit-staff acts as a pointer for highlighting hazards or important mechanics. A faint mist trails behind him, giving him an ethereal but friendly presence.

Personality: Comedic, expressive, and slightly dramatic. Elder Tohu gestures wildly when explaining mechanics and uses humour to make the player feel at ease. Beneath his playful exterior he carries deep wisdom about the mountain, its trials, and the nature of the Mountain Guardian. He enjoys guiding new climbers and takes pride in passing on the lessons he learned during his own ascent.



Gameplay Overview

Risky Peaks is a single-player, third-person, vertical traversal adventure game that combines precision platforming, environmental hazards, and moral decision-making. The player controls Ogunda Climbah, a chosen tribal climber tasked with ascending a sacred mountain to retrieve a rare medicinal plant needed to cure a deadly illness spreading through his village.

The core gameplay focuses on climbing mechanics, stamina management, and environmental navigation across a series of increasingly hostile mountain regions. Each level introduces new traversal challenges and hazards that test the player's timing, spatial awareness, and adaptability.

Player choice plays a central role, as decisions made during the ascent directly influence difficulty, narrative progression, and the game's final outcome.

The mountain itself functions as both setting and antagonist. Through dynamic terrain changes, environmental obstacles, and indirect intervention by the Mountain Guardian, the game ensures that each ascent feels reactive and narratively grounded. Progression is linear in structure but variable in difficulty and outcome, shaped by the player's actions rather than scripted events alone.

Gameplay Experience

The intended gameplay experience of *Risky Peaks* is one of tension, perseverance, and moral responsibility. Players are placed in a high-risk environment where success depends not only on mechanical skill but also on judgement and empathy. The mountain is designed to feel alive and responsive, reinforcing the narrative theme that the climb is both a physical and spiritual trial. Difficulty increases gradually across levels, with early stages acting as onboarding spaces supported by the spectral guide Elder Tohu. As the climb progresses, assistance becomes limited, hazards become less predictable, and consequences for failure become more severe. This escalation mirrors Ogunda's narrative journey from novice climber to tested champion.

Moments of relief and preparation are provided through checkpoint encounters with the merchant Temba, allowing players to recover, upgrade equipment, and reassess strategy. These pauses contrast with the intense traversal sequences, maintaining pacing and preventing player fatigue while reinforcing narrative progression.

Mechanics and Modes

Core Mechanics:

Climbing and Traversal: Players navigate vertical and angled terrain using climbing axes, ledges, jumps, and wall grips.

Stamina Management: Actions such as jumping, climbing, and recovery consume stamina, requiring careful pacing.

Environmental Hazards: Ice, slime, fog, falling debris, lava, and shifting platforms introduce risk and variation.

Totem Placement: Totems act as checkpoints and are also used to rescue stranded climbers.

Branching Difficulty: Route selection influences future level difficulty and final encounter conditions.

Progression Systems:

XP and Upgrades: Experience points are earned through traversal success, rescues, and efficiency.

Merchant Interaction: Temba offers tools, charms, and upgrades that modify traversal and survivability.

Karma System: Player decisions affect merchant prices, item quality, and narrative outcomes.

Game Mode:

Single-Player Narrative Mode (default): The game is designed exclusively as a single-player experience with no multiplayer or competitive modes in the base game.

Enemies and Bosses

Enemies in *Risky Peaks* are primarily environmental and spectral manifestations rather than conventional combat seen in popular games. These include hostile spirits of fallen climbers, animated terrain, and hazard-based obstacles designed to impede progress.

The primary antagonist is the Mountain Guardian, an ancient, god-like entity that embodies the will of the mountain. The Guardian does not engage in traditional combat but instead alters the environment to test the player's worth. The final encounter dynamically adapts based on the player's cumulative choices, resulting in multiple possible endings.

Planned Expansions and Bonus Material

Theorised post release expansions/DLC include:

- Additional mountain routes with alternative hazards.
- New cosmetic tribal gear tied to performance milestones.
- Time-trial challenge modes for completed levels.
- Expanded lore entries unlocked through exploration and rescue completion.
- Multiplayer mode where friends can compete to see who will scale a level the fastest.
- Ingame leaderboards connected to speedrunning websites.

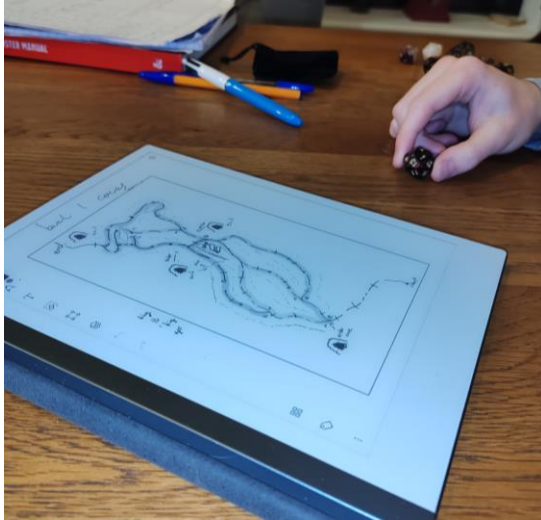
These additions are intended to extend replayability without altering the core narrative structure and will be explored further.

Appendix: Playtests

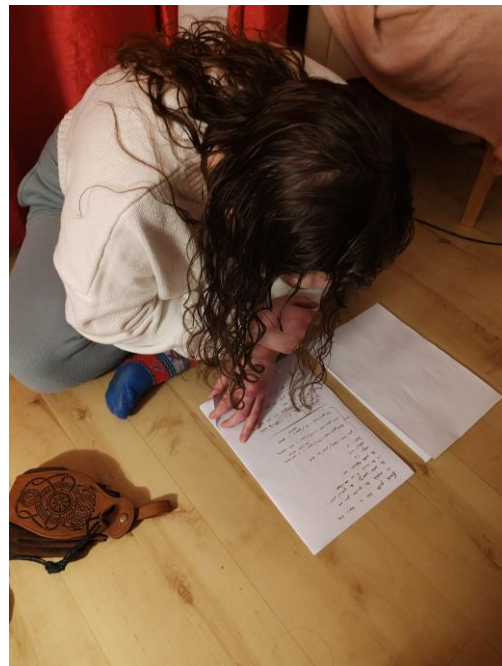
The playtesting of “Risky Peaks” was conducted over a few days including New Years day and the 3rd of January. We had two participants, a fellow player of a D&D campaign I play in, Conor. and a girl Emma. Conor’s playtest was very brief and i had to explain some of the rules to him which led me to tweaking it and setting it up for Emma in a better way. Conor had this to say

“I Like how you have to chose and roll a dice to get over obstacles. Its just you had to tell me that”.

Conors Playtest was used on my paper tablet at the time.

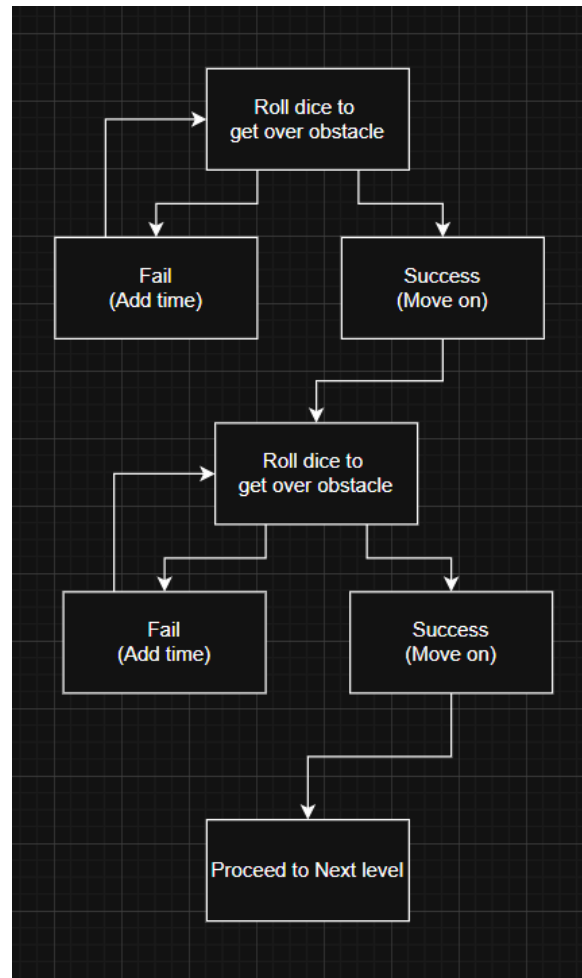


Emmas playtest was used on printed paper and on the floor of her room, and she got to lvl 2 . She had to say she would play it longer if she could and enjoyed adding and subtracting the numbers



Script and Procedure

You would Roll the dice and try get over the obstacles and if you failed the game would punish you and made you slower whereas when you succeed you pass on just with the default paths time. Some hazards would slow you down and add more time along with the fail or make the DC to beat greater, therefore making it harder to beat.



Participants Feedback

A google form was used to collect data on the participants

Timestamp	2026/01/03 8:02:31 pm GMT
did you find the game engaging	Yes
What was the first thing that came to you mind when you started playing	interesting
was it easy or hard to understand	3
did you want to stop playing at all?	No
If answered yes to above, When and Why.	n/a
does this prototype paint a picture of the game idea	Yes
what parts of this prototype do you think we could improve on.	Colours for level of difficulty in paths, boosters to add to dice roll score to improve chances of making jump

what do you think did the prototype do well	Scoring system works well and is not too difficult that I became disengaged in game
do you play any similar games.	
what strategies did you use	I took the hard paths to risk falling for a better score

Familiarity and Similar Games

- The familiarity of this game with Conor was very similar as the dice rolling was very close to that of D&D so he understood it very well. Could be a consideration for players who haven't played D&D before to see how easy they find it.
- Emma liked rolling dice and adding numbers , this isnt the core feature of the game and idea as it would be online.

Goal and Strategy

- Conor just rolled and rolled trying to go to the hardest trail. Not because it was “quicker” but because he said “he aint scared”.
- Emma wanted to take some of the harder trails, but later regretted it after losing a lot of time and said “I should've gone medium”.

Engagement and Enjoyment

- Conor said he had no “drive” to play, but liked the idea, which pushed improvement of playtesting environment
- Emma wanted to play she said she enjoyed playing and said she found the game engaging

Clarity and Understanding

- Conor wasn't very clear on what to do as the instructions were crude at the time.
- After clearing up the instructions Emma was able to understand the rules simply on her own, with some help from me explaining some errors in the documents

Difficulty

- Conor thought the game itself was easy, he just got lost.
- Emma found it easy to play but lost a lot of time.

Analysis of Results & Possible Future Changes

The overall playtest revealed some revelations to us about the game. The playtest mechanics themselves wouldn't be the same as the final product. I.e. rolling a dice compared to controller or keyboard inputs but it was the theme and the drive for the game we were looking for. With some of the playtests this revealed it has some kind of drive to play but that could mean its only fun in its easy state if it could get harder it mightn't be fun anymore. Play testers felt they were climbing a mountain but more felt like they were doing an obstacle course. Again, a limitation of the form of prototype we used. If it was made with computer generated graphics that issue may have been resolved.

The cost of the prototype was around a euro as all i had to do was print some pages of our maps we had already made.

We hadn't added some of the events in the game into the prototype because it would've confused the play testers too much in the form it was made, like the shopkeeper and rescuing survivors. After though we let Emma know that these w'ere planned features and was intrigued into knowing more and thought it was a good idea.

Another crutch to this playtest is that we only got to test the first 2 levels. Which makes the other levels and late game still a mystery of how it would work. If I were to do it again, I may get the players to start later or let them know that it could be a longer session. Other levels had stuff like hazards and special cases which would've been good data to get on if we had done it.

Although both players had experience rolling dice from DnD they both still showed that they liked the gameplay, maybe this game wouldn't be for people who don't like mental maths or rolling for chance.

Steps to improve this prototype. Getting coloured maps as trying to find what path was hard and what was easy was kind of hard when it was black and white, events would be added to test these features and hazards along with longer sessions to test most levels.

The google form could have been better aswell with a few more questions and focusing more on the theme and vision for the game and its future.